STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

Sarah Jacobson

As a Business major at Cal Poly with a concentration in Information Systems, I have developed a passion for data, design, and data visualization. We live in a world that is driven by data and where data is readily available. Companies are becoming increasingly reliant on data to guide their decision making and business strategies. It's exciting Cal Poly offers a program in this relevant and growing field. I believe the Master's in Business Analytics program would allow me to expand my skills and pursue my interest in data analysis and visualization.

I believe Business Analytics is a natural extension of my studies in Information Systems and would give me practical skills valued by employers. Throughout my undergraduate coursework, I have developed strong technical skills in SQL, Python, and R and hope to build on this foundation. In my coursework, I have had several opportunities to work as a member of a team on interesting projects. One project I found especially meaningful involved building an entire database in SQL for a used car business. I enjoyed working with my group to develop a fully functioning database and execute queries to solve business problems. It was rewarding to see how this database could be used to provide insightful information to decision-makers and help them determine next steps for their business. This experience gave me the opportunity to see how the skills I was learning in class could be used to help companies solve business problems.

Another experience that sparked my interest in Business Analytics occurred during my internship last summer with the Insurance Brokerage Firm, Amwins. During this internship, I worked with PowerBi to analyze the Seattle office's current revenue and client relationships in areas across the Pacific Northwest. Using this information, I developed a detailed report identifying new prospective clients and cross-selling opportunities as well as proposed areas where the office could increase its revenue. I enjoyed analyzing reports the company created in PowerBi and using this data to identify new ideas and business strategies. I look forward to learning more data visualization tools in the Business Analytics program to help others understand complex data.

Throughout my life, I have looked for ways to challenge myself and seek opportunities that allow me to grow. While in high school, I had the option to take classes at the local college during my Junior and Senior years to earn dual credit. I worked hard to earn a 4.0 GPA while taking rigorous college courses these last two years of high school. I was one of only a few students to earn an AA degree along with my high school diploma. I am proud to have continued to succeed in the business program at Cal Poly while competing as a division one athlete on the swim team. I believe a Master's in Business Analytics will provide great preparation and allow me to learn beneficial and relevant skills that will increase my value in the workplace. I see myself applying these skills working for a large company using data to create visual reports that communicate a story to help decision makers be strategic with their future business direction.